religious beliefs, customs, traditions and ways of living.

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The more expansive notion of the Chinese nation had geopolitical consequences. The occupation of Tibet in 1950 created a border between India and China for the first time in history. In the west, too, India was separated from Xinjiang by the Kunlun mountains, which even the Qing regarded as their southern frontier. The region between the Kunlun and Karakoram ranges, which includes the vast plateau of Aksai Chin, was never part of the Qing empire even at its maximum extent. But thanks to an ambiguous frontier policy pursued by the British, the jurisdiction of the Jammu and Kashmir princely state over this remote area was rendered suspect.

The extension of the Qing empire into Manchuria over the Amur river brought it into contact with the expanding Russian empire at that time. This was the first such encounter and resulted in the Treaty of Nerchinsk concluded in 1689. Russia would loom very large in the Qing empire's challenge of managing its vast periphery and would lead to the formulation of a distinctive frontier policy. In the late nineteenth/early twentieth century, the Qing empire, already in decline, would be confronted with an unfamiliar challenge – a rising Japan looking at Manchuria for resources to drive its industrialization. India too would come into focus – not as the sacred birthplace of the Buddhist faith but rather as the base for British imperialist depredations against a declining China.

The Opium Wars of 1840–42 and 1856–60, inaugurated China's 'century of humiliation', which marked another watershed in China's long history, generating powerful forces which propelled the country and its people to confront the Western challenge in all its dimensions. Chinese students from the new Western-style Beijing and Tsinghua universities in the capital became an important and influential community pressing for reform.

When the Treaty of Versailles was concluded after the defeat of Germany in the First World War, the territories held by Germany since 1914 in Shandong province were handed over to Japan rather than returned to